

# Treatment of Actinic Keratosis

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## Tracking Information

### Publication Number

100-3

### Manual Section Number

250.4

### Manual Section Title

Treatment of Actinic Keratosis

### Version Number

1

### Effective Date of this Version

11/26/2001

### Implementation Date

11/26/2001

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## Description Information

### Benefit Category

Physician Assistant Services

**Please Note:** This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

### Item/Service Description

Actinic Keratosis (AKs), also known as solar keratoses, are common, sun-induced skin lesions that are confined to the epidermis and have the potential to become a skin cancer.

Various options exist for treating AKs. Clinicians should select an appropriate treatment based on the patient's medical history, the lesion's characteristics, and on the patient's preference for a specific treatment. Commonly performed treatments for AKs include cryosurgery with liquid nitrogen, topical drug therapy, and curettage. Less commonly performed treatments for AK include dermabrasion, excision, chemical peels, laser therapy, and photodynamic therapy. An alternative approach to treating AKs is to observe the lesions over time and remove them only if they exhibit specific clinical features suggesting possible transformation to invasive squamous cell carcinoma.

## Indications and Limitations of Coverage

Effective for services performed on and after November 26, 2001, Medicare covers the destruction of actinic keratoses without restrictions based on lesion or patient characteristics.

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## Transmittal Information

### Transmittal Number

145

### Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/Regulations-and-Guidance/Guidance/Transmittals/Downloads/R145CIM.pdf> [↗](#)

### Revision History

02/2026 - The purpose of this Change Request (CR) is to provide a quarterly maintenance update of ICD-10 coding conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). No policy is being changed as a result of these updates. ([TN 13623](#) [↗](#)) (CR14356)

02/2018 - Transmittal 2033, dated February 16, 2018, is being rescinded and replaced by Transmittal 2039, dated, February 28, 2018 to correct instructions in business requirement 7, NCD210.3, Colorectal Cancer Screening, and its accompanying spreadsheet. All other information remains the same. ([TN 2039](#) [↗](#)) (CR10473)

02/2018 - This Change Request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of International Code of Diseases, Tenth Revision (ICD-10) conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates that can be found at: <https://www.cms.gov/Medicare/Coverage/CoverageGenInfo/ICD10.html> [↗](#), along with other CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. ([TN 2033](#) [↗](#)) (CR10473)

05/2014 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 10/06/2014 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1388](#) [↗](#)) ([TN 1388](#) [↗](#)) (CR 8691)

09/2012 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any

necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/07/2013 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1122](#)) ([TN 1122](#)) (CR 7818)

10/2001 - Extended coverage for surgical or medical treatment methods, including but not limited to cryosurgery with liquid nitrogen, curettage, excision, and photodynamic therapy, without restrictions based on patient or lesion characteristics. Medicare contractors retain discretion to determine number of visits considered reasonable and necessary to treat these lesions. Effective and implementation dates 11/26/2001. ([TN 145](#)) (CR 1892)

## National Coverage Analyses (NCAs)

This NCD has been or is currently being reviewed under the National Coverage Determination process. The following are existing associations with NCAs, from the National Coverage Analyses database.

- [Original Consideration for Actinic Keratoses \(CAG-00049N\)](#)

## Additional Information

| Other Versions                 |         |                   |                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------|---------|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Title                          | Version | Effective Between |  |
| Treatment of Actinic Keratosis | 1       | 11/26/2001 - N/A  | You are here                                                                          |